

THE MAGICLESS ARCHMAGE

Volume 1: The Artifact Master

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Chapter 1: The Sparks of Fraud

The autumn rain in the rural fief of Oakhaven never seemed to wash away the smell of damp soil and squalor. Inside the minor lord's drafty, neglected archive room, seventeen-year-old Reminus sat on a rotting wooden crate, his dirt-stained fingers tracing the fading gilded lettering of a heavy leather tome.

Unlike the other peasant boys who dreamed of joining the Lord's vanguard, swinging heavy steel swords, and wearing polished iron plate armor, Reminus dreamed of stars. He dreamed of the quiet, humming power of the arcane. He wanted to bend the elements to his will.

But in the kingdom of Alveria, magic was not a skill you simply learned through hard work. It was a birthright. A gift of blood. You either inherited the magical spark in your veins at birth, or you spent your life tilling the muddy wheat fields until your back gave out.

Reminus had no spark. His blood was as mundane as the dirt beneath his fingernails.

Yet, destiny had a strange way of playing tricks on the desperate.

Just three nights ago, while scavenging for scrap metal in the forbidden ruins of the Whispering Spire, Reminus's spade had struck something metallic. Buried beneath centuries of ash was a small, bronze ring embedded with a cracked, cloudy purple amethyst.

It wasn't a relic of legendary power. It was a Spark-Ring—a common, low-grade utility artifact discarded by some wealthy wizard's apprentice decades ago. It possessed no grand destructive capability. All it could do was ignite a candle flame or emit a faint, crackling purple spark when pressed against a hard surface.

But to a boy with nothing, a single spark was enough to ignite a wildfire of deception.

Reminus slipped the cold bronze ring onto his finger, concealed beneath his tattered woolen sleeve. He closed his eyes, pressed the ring against his palm, and whispered a word he had memorized from the old books.

"Ignis."

With a sharp crack, a tiny violet flame danced upon his fingertips. It carried no warmth, nor did it have the power to burn down a wall, but in the dim shadow of the archive room, it looked exactly like the birth of a mage.

Reminus smiled. For the first time in his life, he saw a way out of the mud.